

Hunters on the ice

When the Arctic Ocean freezes over, land predators are able to wander far out onto the ice in search of prey. Two Arctic hunters make a habit of this—the polar bear and the Arctic fox. Both are highly adapted for surviving the cold, but the polar bear in particular is so specialized for life on the ice that it spends more time at sea than on land.



PROWLING FOX

The Arctic fox hunts mainly on land, where it preys on lemmings and other small mammals. But in spring (the seal breeding season), it heads out onto the ice looking for seal pups to kill. The Arctic fox also trails polar bears to feast on their leftovers. Its very dense white winter coat keeps it warm in the bitter Arctic chill, and it can even sleep on the ice.

▲ HIDDEN PREY

An Arctic fox finds prey beneath the snow using its sensitive ears and acute sense of smell. It then pounces on its prey from a height to pin it down.

SUMMER COAT

In summer, the Arctic fox sheds its thick white winter coat in favor of a thinner brownish one. This stops it from overheating, and also gives it better camouflage on land when the winter snow has melted. Some Arctic foxes, known as blue foxes, have dark blue-gray coats that they keep all year round. But these foxes mainly live on rocky shores, and rarely hunt on sea ice.



WOW!

The Arctic fox's fur is so good at keeping out the cold that the fox does not start to shiver until the temperature drops to -94°F (-70°C).

Polar bears are the largest bears in the world.

